FOUR

The Third Indo-Pakistani War and the Birth of Bangladesh

From its birth, Pakistan was plagued by the insoluble division of its territory into two wings, with a thousand miles of northern India between them. The Pakistan Resolution unanimously adopted by Jinnah's Muslim League in Lahore in 1940 had been drafted by a committee chaired by the League's most popular Bengali leader, A. K. Fazlul Haq. The most important section of that resolution, which never mentioned Pakistan by name, stated that

> no constitutional plan would be workable in this country [British India] or acceptable to the Muslims unless it is designed on the following basic principles, viz., that geographically contiguous units are demarcated into regions which should be so constituted, with such territorial adjustments as may be necessary, that the areas in which the Muslims are numerically in a majority, as in the North-Western and Eastern zones of India, should be *grouped to constitute Independent States* in which the constituent units shall be autonomous and sovereign.[1]

When Jinnah was asked by the press if this resolution meant one or more than one Pakistan, he immediately answered, "One!" and thus it was reported next day, in England as well as in India. There is good reason to believe, however, that Sher-i-Bengal (Lion of Bengal) Fazlul Haq had meant *two* independent states, rather than one, and that the easternmost of those "autonomous and sovereign" constituent units of